

Incident Postmortem - PNW Flash Sale Throughput

Underperforming regional MMS send during the Trailhead Flash Sale.

INCIDENT ID	RF-INC-2025-0822-PNW	SEVERITY	SEV-2 marketing impact
START	August 22, 2025 5:30 PM PT	RESOLVED	August 22, 2025 7:44 PM PT
AUTHORS	Messaging Operations + Lifecycle	STATUS	Closed October 1, 2025

Corpus notice: This is a synthetic demonstration document created for Cortex Search evaluation. Brand names, people, metrics, URLs, short codes, and incidents are fictional.

1. Summary

The Pacific Northwest MMS branch of Juniper & Coast campaign JC-BRD-2025-0822 launched at 5:30 PM PT on August 22, 2025 using a 3 transactions-per-second fallback route instead of the approved 75 TPS production route. The first messages were sent on time, but the 23,804-recipient batch required 134 minutes to complete rather than the expected 5-7 minutes.

No messages were sent after the RelayFox 8:00 PM local policy cutoff, no consent or opt-out controls failed, and no data was lost. The incident was classified SEV-2 because it materially reduced campaign performance and exposed a route-validation gap.

2. Customer and business impact

Metric	Expected	Actual	Impact
Batch completion	5:37 PM PT	7:44 PM PT	2 hours 7 minutes late
Unique CTR	8.9%	5.1%	-3.8 percentage points
Attributed orders	435	243	-192 orders
Attributed revenue	\$51,900	\$28,460	-\$23,440 versus target
Opt-out rate	0.30%	0.34%	Within alert threshold
Messages after 8 PM	0	0	No quiet-hour policy breach

The national Trailhead Flash Sale still generated \$286,740, but the PNW shortfall accounted for roughly 75% of the total \$31,260 miss versus campaign plan. Q3 regional revenue per send closed at \$0.286 in PNW, below the \$0.301-\$0.344 range of the other major regions.

3. Timeline (Pacific Time)

Time	Event
4:52 PM	Lifecycle operator replaced the SMS image with an updated Ridgeway Anorak MMS asset.
5:07 PM	Composer revalidation reset the route selector to JC Fallback, a 3 TPS route intended for tests below 2,000 recipients. No blocking warning appeared.
5:23 PM	Final approval completed. Audience size, copy, link, and quiet-hour projection passed; route/TPS was not included in the approval summary.
5:30 PM	PNW branch launched to 23,804 recipients.
5:41 PM	Standard throughput alert did not fire because the monitor counted SMS segments but excluded MMS queue depth.
6:12 PM	Lifecycle noticed lower-than-expected delivery completion and opened Operations ticket OPS-4417.
6:26 PM	Operations identified the fallback route. New queue entries were moved to the 75 TPS production route; already accepted carrier batches remained paced.
7:44 PM	Final queued message delivered. Incident moved to monitoring.
Aug 23, 10:00 AM	Team decided not to resend; projected incremental revenue did not justify fatigue and overlap with the scheduled reminder.

4. Root cause and contributing factors

Primary root cause

The campaign composer did not preserve the approved production route when the message type changed from SMS to MMS during final creative replacement. It selected the account default fallback route, and the approval view did not display route name, approved TPS, or projected completion time.

Contributing factors

- The fallback route allowed a production audience because its 2,000-recipient safeguard existed only in the API, not the web composer.
- The queue-depth alert excluded MMS, so the system did not compare actual completion with the 5:37 PM projection.
- The launch checklist validated message content, consent, links, and quiet hours but not route throughput.
- The operator saw the launch begin at 5:30 PM and assumed normal pacing because seed devices received the message promptly.

5. What worked

- Consent suppression, STOP handling, and frequency caps operated normally.
- The 8:00 PM local hard stop projected risk and prevented any late retry from entering the queue.
- Operations corrected the route within 14 minutes of ticket creation.
- Attribution logs made regional revenue impact measurable and consistent with RF-CB-001 and RF-QBR-008.

6. Corrective and preventive actions

Action	Owner	Due	Status
Preserve route on SMS-to-MMS conversion and display route/TPS in approval summary	Messaging Platform	Sep 5, 2025	Completed Sep 4
Block fallback routes for audiences above 2,000 in web and API	Messaging Platform	Sep 5, 2025	Completed Sep 5
Add MMS queue depth and completion-time variance alert	Site Reliability	Sep 12, 2025	Completed Sep 11
Add route/TPS preflight to campaign launch checklist	Messaging Operations	Sep 5, 2025	Completed Sep 3
Create 5% regional holdout standard for large broadcasts	Growth Analytics	Oct 1, 2025	Completed Oct 1
Backfill completion-time field into campaign audit export	Data Platform	Oct 15, 2025	Completed Oct 13

7. Verification

On September 18, 2025, Juniper & Coast sent the PNW Rain Check broadcast to 31,220 recipients. The preflight selected the 75 TPS route, projected 7 minutes 12 seconds, and completed in 7 minutes 41 seconds. Unique CTR was 8.2%, and no alert or quiet-hour threshold was breached.

Related corpus documents: Campaign Brief - Q3 Trailhead Flash Sale (RF-CB-001), Deliverability & Carrier Best Practices (RF-OPS-005), Quarterly Performance Review - Q3 2025 (RF-QBR-008), and Attribution Methodology Whitepaper (RF-WP-009).